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CANCEL CULTURE & *Digital Ethics*

Agenda

Where Does Accountability Become Online Harm?

01 Social control

02 Moral emotions

03 Digital platforms

04 Digital ethics

INTRODUCTION

Research question

Under what conditions does cancel culture support accountability, and when does it become harmful online punishment?

Working definition

Cancel culture - publicly withdrawing support from individuals or organisations because of perceived wrongdoing.

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Who defines right and wrong?

Accountability or punishment?

LOADING...

Online communities can challenge powerful people when institutions fail to respond.

But public pressure can become punishment without clear standards or a fair chance to respond.

Cultural perspective

Cancel culture reveals conflicts over shared values, identity, and who has the authority to judge others.

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Durkheim's concept

Lubis links uncertain norms and weakened institutional trust to informal digital sanctions.

MORAL EMOTIONS

What drives the backlash?

FABINDIA

19.25% DISGUST

8,420 posts analysed
Cultural & religious identity

ZARA

18.18% ANGER

9,105 posts analysed Humanitarian concerns

DIFFERENT CONCERNS

Different emotional reactions

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DIGITAL PLATFORMS

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Two cases, two different meanings

CASE	TRIGGER	CULTURAL SIGNIFICANCE
Fabindia, 2021	Some users objected to the Urdu phrase “Jashn-e-Riwaaz” in a festive campaign.	Language became a disputed symbol of religious identity, cultural belonging and representation
Zara, 2023	Some viewers associated campaign imagery with suffering in Gaza	Advertising was interpreted through humanitarian concerns and political conflict.

HOW PLATFORMS SHAPE REACTIONS

Hashtags connect individual reactions into shared discussions. Reposts spread interpretations beyond the original audience. Platform visibility can turn criticism into collective pressure.

CONNECTION TO IT

BERT-based classification helps identify emotions expressed in posts. NLTK-assisted text analysis helps researchers examine language patterns across large collections of online reactions.

DIGITAL ETHICS

Accountability or online harm?

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ETHICAL ACCOUNTABILITY

- Checks evidence and context
- Criticises specific actions
- Uses proportionate responses
- Allows explanations and correction

HARMFUL ONLINE PUNISHMENT

- Treats viral claims as proven facts
- Attacks personal identity or private life
- Encourages threats, harassment, or doxxing
- Rejects dialogue and any possibility of change

THREE RESEARCH LENSES

Lubis
Institutional trust

Driessen et al.
Media, power and moral judgement

Maheshwari et al.
Emotions and brand recovery

OUR INTERPRETATION

Recovering a reputation and resolving an ethical problem are different outcomes.

CONCLUSION AND PRACTICAL SIGNIFICANCE

Answer to our research question

Cancel culture can support accountability when criticism is evidence-based, proportionate, and open to correction. It becomes harmful when collective outrage replaces verification and encourages

Recommendations

Users: verify information before sharing accusations.
Platforms: address harassment while preserving legitimate criticism.
Organisations: acknowledge concerns and explain concrete corrective actions.
Universities: teach digital literacy through discussion of real cases.

Research limitation

Our selected studies do not establish how all societies experience cancel culture. Research in Kazakhstan should examine local contexts and Kazakh- and Russian-language discussions.

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